

MSI Titan 18 HX AI (2025)

Desktop-class power, laptop form

Every once in a while, a gaming laptop shows up that skips the whole subtlety thing and just screams performance. The MSI Titan 18 HX AI is that machine for 2025. With a 24-core Intel Core Ultra 9 285HX, Nvidia's top-tier RTX 5090 GPU, 64GB of DDR5-6400 RAM, and 6TB of PCIe Gen 5 storage in RAID 0, it doesn't pretend to be reasonable, and that's the point.

To put it through its paces, I also paired the Titan with a bunch of Thunderbolt 5 accessories, from ultra-fast SSDs to hubs and cables, to see how far the new port standard can stretch when it's being backed by a system this powerful.

DESIGN, BUILD QUALITY

This laptop is massive. At nearly 8 pounds (3.6 kg), the Titan 18 HX AI isn't trying to be portable, it's more like a desktop with a hinge. But the magnesium-aluminium chassis goes a long way in making it feel solid and premium, without feeling plasticky or flimsy like some other oversized gaming machines. There's zero deck flex, the hinges are robust, and the lid opens with one hand, MSI has clearly paid attention to structural integrity.

Visually, it's a blend of brute force and polish. The RGB-lit touchpad and glowing dragon logo give it the gamer flair you'd expect, but it's the subtle turquoise accents on the rear vents that add character. Despite its size, the laptop doesn't scream "gamer" obnoxiously, which is appreciated for



anyone planning to use this machine for creative workloads too.

DISPLAY AND AUDIO

If there's one component that truly makes the MSI Titan 18 HX AI feel like

a flagship, it's the display. Front and centre is a massive 18-inch 4K (3840 x 2400) Mini-LED panel with a smooth 120Hz refresh rate and a productivity-friendly 16:10 aspect ratio. This isn't just a spec flex, the panel is jaw-droppingly bright, peaking at 762 nits in HDR and maintaining a strong 729 nits even in SDR. Whether it's the dusty textures of Andor or the glossy tarmac of F1 24, visuals feel cinematic, layered, and detailed. The screen's HDR performance is where it truly shines, with punchy highlights and true blacks.

That said, while the display immerses you visually, the audio experience doesn't quite keep up. The Titan houses a quad-speaker setup paired with dual woofers, and while it certainly gets loud enough to fill a room, the

sound profile leans heavily toward the mids. Explosions in Cyberpunk 2077 feel a bit hollow, and bass-heavy music loses much of its depth and warmth. This is particularly noticeable in action-heavy games or cinematic content where sound plays a critical role. There's clarity, sure, but the lack of low-end punch makes the experience feel incomplete without external speakers or a good pair of headphones.

Still, this slight mismatch doesn't take away from the fact that the Titan's display is among the best in the business, not just for gamers but for creators and power users alike. If you regularly toggle between Premiere Pro timelines and high-refresh gaming sessions, the colour accuracy, brightness consistency, and sheer screen real estate are an everyday luxury. It sets an all new bar for gaming laptop displays, even if the audio can't keep up with the amazing display it has.

PERFORMANCE BENCHMARKS

By now, it should be clear, the MSI Titan 18 HX AI is the fastest gaming laptop we've tested. Still, while some aspects of this machine are genuinely surprising, others feel exactly as expected.

First up in CPU performance, the Intel Core Ultra 9 285HX scored 34543 in multicore and 2152 in single core test in Cinebench R23. It is the highest score ever, but not by much. Because the HP Omen Max that we tested recently which has the Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX scored around 33549 in multicore and 2142 in single core tests.

Functionally, both laptop processors offer the same core configuration: 8 Performance cores, 16 Efficiency cores, and 24 threads. The main difference lies in clock speeds: the Intel Core Ultra 9 285HX has a higher Max Turbo Frequency of 5.5 GHz versus 5.4 GHz on the 275HX. Similarly, its P-core Base Frequency is 2.8 GHz, slightly above the 2.7 GHz of the 275HX.

And that brings me to my main concern with this laptop. The Intel